POINT OF CHANGE / TECHNOLOGY

The Judgment You Need to Keep

Give people better material to decide with, and make clear who makes the decision.



Fran Herrera · Co-founder, Strategy & Operations
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A client asks whether a change to the lobby can be included in the fee. Their message sounds minor. Your project manager knows the designer already issued a drawing package, the manufacturer's hold expires tomorrow, and the superintendent needs an answer before the ceiling closes. A tool can pull those facts together and draft a response. The answer commits the business to a price, a date and a way of delivering the work.

That's the moment to define what assistance means.

Keep decisions with an authorized person when they depend on incomplete facts, professional judgment, exceptions, or consequential commitments to a customer. A tool can collect evidence, show conflicts and draft options. Decide which steps it may carry out, what must be reviewed, and how the team can recover if the proposed action is wrong.

Where does preparation become a commitment?

The boundary is the first action that changes what the company or customer can rely on. A summary prepares a review. An approved price or promised completion date changes the engagement. For each action, ask who can verify the facts and who has the authority to make that promise.

Erik Brynjolfsson, Danielle Li and Lindsey Raymond studied a staggered rollout of a conversational assistant using data from 5,172 customer-support agents at one company. Issues resolved per hour increased about 15% on average, with gains varying substantially by worker. The assistant offered suggestions to people handling chats. The study shows why preparing an answer can be valuable and why a single average tells you little about who benefits most. A service firm's responsibility for pricing a project change requires its own test. Brynjolfsson, Li and Raymond, Generative AI at Work

Think about choosing a route in Google Maps. It can compare routes and estimate arrival times. It also lets you specify whether to avoid tolls or adjust when you plan to arrive. You know whether it's worth paying a toll to make the meeting. For the lobby change, write down the equivalent choice. Is the opening date fixed? Is there room in the budget to protect it? Give those constraints to the tool when they're known, and give the remaining trade-off to the person who can make it. Google Maps Help on route options and arrival times

For the lobby, preparation could include opening the latest accepted scope, finding the deadline and listing the work affected. A recommendation could compare keeping the current design and pricing the change. The project lead verifies the implications. The authorized commercial person decides the fee and the commitment the client will receive.

What can a tool do independently?

Give it the tasks with reliable inputs, a defined rule and a verifiable result. Limit independent action where a wrong step is difficult to undo or relies on a fact the tool cannot check. Review which employee is responsible for each exception.

Work on the lobby change	Useful assistance	Decision or action to check
Find the current commitment.	Retrieve the accepted proposal, approved drawing and relevant messages.	Project lead verifies the applicable versions.
Compare options.	Draft a summary of design, price and schedule consequences with links to the evidence.	Technical lead verifies compatibility and delivery implications.
Confirm the change to the client.	Prepare a draft using the approved terms.	Authorized person accepts the commitment and sends or approves the message.
Remind the team to check supplier availability.	Send an internal reminder from the confirmed deadline.	Route missing or conflicting dates for review.

A system may assemble a confident account from documents that disagree. The test is whether the employee can see the conflict and reach the governing source. A tool that makes the decision look simpler than it is can increase the time and skill required to catch the error.

How do you test whether assistance preserves judgment?

Run representative normal cases and exceptions through the proposed workflow before letting it act on live jobs. Compare the proposed answer with the actual documents and ask the decision owner which parts still require a call. Record the time spent reviewing, missed exceptions and commitments that would have gone out in error.

Use a decision matrix that lists the requested action, evidence required, permissible assistance, authorized person, and point of review. Include a late revision and a request with no approved supplier price. Compare the results for experienced and newer employees. A tool may be useful to the latter and slow down people who already know where to look.

Give the reviewer a case where the approved scope says two site visits and a later email suggests a third. If the tool drafts a reply that includes the third visit in the fee, trace what it used. The draft should surface the two records and let an authorized person resolve the difference. Record whether the employee caught the conflict, how long it took and what would have reached the client if the draft went out unchanged.

Three checks before giving a tool responsibility.

- Identify the exact action that commits the company or changes the customer's position.
- Keep the evidence and uncertainty visible to the person who can authorize it.
- Measure time, exception handling and the quality of the decision together.

The client still deserves a quick answer about the lobby. Give the project lead the current scope, show the clock on the manufacturer's hold, and let the person accountable for the work say what the company can promise.

Frequently asked questions

Can routine messages be sent automatically?

Yes, when the event and wording are well defined and the system can verify the facts. Decide how to handle missing inputs or a customer who has already received a different answer.

What should we measure besides time saved?

Track missed exceptions, corrections, customer outcomes and the time it takes people to review the recommendation. Include problems the receiving team discovers later.

Who owns a bad automated decision?

Assign an owner before deployment. That person should be able to investigate the decision, correct the customer's record, and pause or change the rule that produced it.

The lobby scenario is illustrative. The study concerns a specific customer-support setting.